

Humility - God's Definition

What humility looks like in Scripture — Old Testament and New Testament
BibleHub search: HUMILITY, with the related words God actually uses

Source search: biblehub.com/search.php?q=HUMILITY (36 English hits on the word *humility*). That list is not the whole field. God also speaks through humble, meek, lowly, poor in spirit, afflict the soul, bow down, and related Hebrew and Greek roots.

Questions: What does humility look like in the Bible? Is there such a thing as too much godly humility? Can a wife give her husband too much humility, or a husband give his wife too much?

Line that must not be blurred: Godly humility is lowliness of mind under God. It is not self-hatred, silence in the face of sin, worship of angels, harsh treatment of the body, or a spouse becoming a doormat. Scripture names a *false* humility. The real thing has no excess; the counterfeit has no virtue.

I. The Word Field — Not One English Word

English Bibles often print “humility” where the original says several different things. God’s definition is the combined picture, not a single glossary entry.

Language	Word (Strong’s)	Sense in Scripture	Sample
Hebrew	<i>anavah</i> (H6038)	Humility, meekness, gentleness — lowliness that fears the LORD	Proverbs 15:33; 18:12; 22:4; Zephaniah 2:3
Hebrew	<i>anav</i> (H6035)	Humble / meek as a people God favors	Numbers 12:3; Psalm 37:11; Isaiah 29:19
Hebrew	<i>anah</i> (H6031)	To humble, afflict, bow the soul (including fasting / Day of Atonement)	Leviticus 16:29; 23:27–29; Deuteronomy 8:2–3
Hebrew	<i>kana</i> (H3665)	To humble oneself, be subdued — often repentance under God’s hand	2 Chronicles 7:14; 12:6–7
Hebrew	<i>shaphel</i> (H8213/H8217)	To be made low; God brings down the proud	Isaiah 2:11–12; 57:15
Greek	<i>tapeinophrosyne</i> (G5012)	Lowliness of mind — the usual NT noun “humility”	Acts 20:19; Philippians 2:3; Colossians 3:12; 1 Peter 5:5; also Colossians 2:18, 23 of <i>false</i> humility

Language	Word (Strong's)	Sense in Scripture	Sample
Greek	<i>tapeinos</i> / <i>tapeinoo</i> (G5011 / G5013)	Humble; to humble (oneself or be humbled)	Matthew 11:29; 23:12; Philippians 2:8; James 4:6, 10; 1 Peter 5:6
Greek	<i>praus</i> / <i>prautes</i> (G4239 / G4240)	Meek, gentle — strength under God's bit, not limpness	Matthew 5:5; 11:29; Galatians 5:23; 6:1; 2 Timothy 2:25

BibleHub's 36-verse HUMILITY list includes several translation choices that are not the same Greek or Hebrew word (for example some versions put "humility" at Galatians 5:23 where most have gentleness / meekness; or at Mark 15:19 for mock kneeling). That is useful: it shows how easily English can mix true lowliness with theater.

II. What Humility Looks Like in the Bible

1. It is the fear of the LORD, not a personality type

Proverbs 22:4 — The reward of humility and the fear of the LORD are riches, honor, and life.

Proverbs 15:33 — The fear of the LORD is the instruction of wisdom, and before honor is humility.

Godly humility is not shyness, self-deprecation, or social rank. It is the settled recognition that God is God and I am not. Proverbs binds it to the fear of the LORD. Without that fear, what looks like humility is only manners.

2. It comes before honor; pride comes before a fall

Proverbs 18:12 — Before destruction the heart of man is haughty, and before honor is humility.

Proverbs 11:2 — When pride comes, then comes disgrace, but with the humble is wisdom.

Proverbs 29:23 — A man's pride will bring him low, but a humble spirit will obtain honor.

Humility is not the opposite of dignity. God's path to honor is downward first. The world's path is self-exaltation, then collapse.

3. It is a walk, not a pose

Micah 6:8 — He has told you, O man, what is good; and what does the LORD require of you but to do justice, to love kindness, and to walk humbly with your God?

Zephaniah 2:3 — Seek the LORD, all you humble of the earth who have carried out His ordinances; seek righteousness, seek humility. Perhaps you will be hidden in the day of the LORD's anger.

Humility walks with God. It does justice and loves kindness. A person who is "humble" toward men but unjust toward the weak is not walking in *anavah*.

4. God dwells with it; He opposes pride

Isaiah 57:15 — For thus says the high and exalted One who lives forever, whose name is Holy: I dwell on a high and holy place, and also with the contrite and lowly of spirit, in order to revive the spirit of the lowly and to revive the heart of the contrite.

Isaiah 66:2 — To this one I will look, to him who is humble and contrite of spirit, and who trembles at My word.

James 4:6; 1 Peter 5:5 — God is opposed to the proud, but gives grace to the humble.

Humility is the address where God lives among men. Pride is the address He wars against. This is the same sentence in Proverbs 3:34, James, and Peter. It is not a New Testament invention.

5. It receives God's word and God's discipline

James 1:21 — Receive with meekness the implanted word, which is able to save your souls.

Deuteronomy 8:2–3 — The LORD led you in the wilderness to humble you, testing you, that He might make you know that man does not live by bread alone.

Leviticus 23:27, 29 — On the Day of Atonement you shall humble your souls; whoever does not shall be cut off from his people.

Humility is teachable. It lets God reduce the soul so that His word, not appetite, is bread. Israel's calendar even required a day of self-humbling. Refusal was not "healthy self-esteem." It was covenant-breaking.

6. It looks like service, tears, and considering others

Acts 20:19 — Serving the Lord with all humility and with tears and with trials.

Philippians 2:3 — Do nothing from selfishness or empty conceit, but with humility of mind regard one another as more important than yourselves.

Ephesians 4:2 — With all humility and gentleness, with patience, showing tolerance for one another in love.

Colossians 3:12 — Put on a heart of compassion, kindness, humility, gentleness, and patience.

1 Peter 5:5 — All of you, clothe yourselves with humility toward one another.

This is what it looks like on the ground: serving, weeping, bearing with people, ranking others above self, wearing humility the way you wear a garment. It is not a mood. It is a chosen mind (*tapeinophrosyne* — lowliness of *phroneo*, how you think).

7. Its perfect picture is Jesus Christ

Matthew 11:29 — Take My yoke upon you and learn from Me, for I am gentle and humble in heart, and you will find rest for your souls.

Philippians 2:5–8 — Have this mind in you which was also in Christ Jesus... He emptied Himself, taking the form of a servant... He humbled Himself by becoming obedient to the point of death, even death on a cross.

2 Corinthians 10:1 — I, Paul, myself urge you by the meekness and gentleness of Christ.

Acts 8:33 (Isaiah 53) — In His humiliation justice was taken away from Him.

God's definition is a Person. The Son did not cease to be Lord when He became a servant. He did not cease to speak truth, cleanse the temple, or name wolves. He lowered Himself in obedience to the Father, even to the cross. That is humility: not loss of identity, but refusal of self-will.

8. It is meek strength, not collapse

Numbers 12:3 — Now the man Moses was very humble, more than any man who was on the face of the earth.

Psalms 45:4 — Ride on in majesty for the cause of truth, humility, and righteousness.

Galatians 6:1 — Restore such a one in a spirit of gentleness, looking to yourself, lest you too be tempted.

2 Timothy 2:25 — With gentleness correcting those who are in opposition, if perhaps God may grant them repentance.

Moses was the meekest man and still confronted Pharaoh, Korah, and Israel. Meekness restores the fallen and corrects opponents. It does not pretend sin is not there. Paul served “with all humility” and still warned night and day with tears (Acts 20:19, 31).

9. Scripture itself names a false humility

Colossians 2:18 — Let no one keep defrauding you of your prize by delighting in self-abasement and the worship of the angels... inflated without cause by his fleshly mind.

Colossians 2:23 — These have the appearance of wisdom in self-made religion and self-abasement and severe treatment of the body, but are of no value against fleshly indulgence.

Mark 15:19 — They kept beating His head and spitting on Him, and kneeling and bowing before Him (mock homage).

False humility is puffed up. It looks low and is proud. It worships visions, angels, rules, and the body's pain. It does not kill the flesh; it feeds it. Soldiers kneeling to Jesus were not humble. They were performing.

III. Is There Such a Thing as Too Much Godly Humility?

Of the real thing: no. You cannot have too much fear of the LORD, too much of Christ's mind, or too much clothing of humility. God never warns, "Be less humble toward Me." He warns the opposite: humble yourselves under the mighty hand of God (1 Peter 5:6). James 4:10: "Humble yourselves in the presence of the Lord, and He will exalt you." The limit is not quantity. The limit is *object* and *kind*.

Of the counterfeit: yes, and Scripture already named it. What people call "too much humility" is almost always one of these, none of which is godly:

Counterfeit	What it does	Why it is not godly humility
Self-abasement / ascetic show	Punishes the body, parades lowliness	Colossians 2:18, 23 — appearance of wisdom; no power against the flesh; the mind is inflated
Sober-mindedness inverted	"I am nothing, my gifts are nothing, I must never speak"	Romans 12:3 — do not think more highly than you ought, but think <i>so as to have sound judgment</i> . God assigned a measure of faith. Denying the gift is not humility; it is unbelief toward the Giver
People-pleasing	Yields to men against God	Galatians 1:10; Acts 5:29 — we must obey God rather than men. Fear of man is a snare (Proverbs 29:25)
Refusal to judge righteous judgment	Will not restore, correct, or expose darkness	Galatians 6:1; 2 Timothy 2:25; Ephesians 5:11; John 7:24. Meekness does the hard word. Silence that protects sin is not lowliness of mind
False lowliness that still wants a throne	Uses "I'm just a worm" to manipulate, or to avoid duty	Matthew 6:16–18 — fasting for men's eyes; Mark 15:19 — kneeling as theater

Jesus was perfectly humble and still said, "Woe to you" (Matthew 23). He was humble and still drove out the money changers. Paul was humble in presence and bold in letter when the church needed it (2 Corinthians 10:1–11). Humility and courage are not two dials that trade off. In Christ they are one mind: the Father's will above mine, and my neighbor's good above my pride — never God's truth below a man's feelings.

So: there is no excess of godly humility. There is a surplus of *false* humility that looks like too much bowing and is actually pride, fear, or sloth wearing a costume.

IV. Husband and Wife — Can Either Give Too Much Humility?

The same rule holds in marriage, with the added clarity of how God ordered the house.

1. Both are commanded to wear humility toward one another

1 Peter 5:5 — All of you, clothe yourselves with humility toward one another.

Ephesians 5:21 — Be subject to one another in the fear of Christ.

Philippians 2:3 — In humility regard one another as more important than yourselves.

1 Corinthians 7:3–4 — The husband must fulfill his duty to his wife, and likewise the wife to her husband. The wife does not have authority over her own body, but the husband does; and likewise also the husband does not have authority over his own body, but the wife does.

Before headship and submission are even named in Ephesians 5, there is mutual subjection in the fear of Christ. Neither spouse is licensed to be proud. Neither is a god. The husband is not Christ; he is to *imitate* Christ's giving. The wife is not the church in glory; she is to honor as the church honors Christ. Both consider the other. Both owe the body. That is already a lot of humility, and God calls it good.

2. The wife's humility is not self-erasure

Ephesians 5:22–24 — Wives, be subject to your own husbands as to the Lord... as the church is subject to Christ.

Colossians 3:18 — Wives, be subject to your husbands, as is fitting in the Lord.

1 Peter 3:1–6 — Wives, be submissive to your own husbands... with the imperishable quality of a gentle and quiet spirit, which is precious in the sight of God.

A wife can give her husband the real thing without measure: honor, a gentle spirit, willingness to follow as is fitting *in the Lord*. The phrase “in the Lord / as to the Lord” is the ceiling. She does not humble herself into sin. She does not call evil good to keep peace. She does not treat her husband as an idol.

If “humility” means she never speaks a hard truth, never refuses what God forbids, never seeks help when he is violent or adulterous, never obeys God above him — that is not biblical humility. That is fear, or a vow to a man that belongs only to God. Acts 5:29 still applies in the house. Abigail restrained David from bloodguilt and was called discerning (1 Samuel 25). That was not rebellion. It was humility toward God that served her household.

3. The husband's humility is not abdication

Ephesians 5:25–29 — Husbands, love your wives, just as Christ also loved the church and gave Himself up for her... husbands ought also to love their own wives as their own bodies.

Colossians 3:19 — Husbands, love your wives and do not be embittered against them.

1 Peter 3:7 — You husbands in the same way, live with your wives in an understanding way, as with someone weaker, since she is a woman; and show her honor as a fellow heir of the grace of life, so that your prayers will not be hindered.

Christ's humility did not consist in ceasing to be Head. It consisted in laying down His life for the body. A husband can never give too much of *that*: too much listening, too much honor, too much washing with the word, too much refusal to be harsh, too much treating her as a fellow heir. His prayers are blocked if he withholds honor (1 Peter 3:7). That is how seriously God takes a husband's lowliness toward his wife.

If "humility" means he will not lead, will not protect, will not name sin, will not keep a vow, will not provide, or will let her bear a weight God put on him — that is not humility. That is sloth dressed as meekness. If "humility" means he grovels to keep her from anger while he still rules in secret, that is theater. If he uses headship without the cross, that is pride, not masculinity.

4. So can either give "too much"?

Too much of God's kind: no. A wife cannot overdo fearing the Lord, a quiet spirit, and honor that is fitting in the Lord. A husband cannot overdo Christ-like self-giving, understanding, and honor. Philippians 2:3 applies both directions inside the marriage. There is no verse that says, "Consider your spouse as more important — but not that much."

Too much of the counterfeit: yes, and it destroys the house.

	False "too much humility"	Godly humility (no excess)
Wife toward husband	Calling his sin a mystery; hiding abuse; agreeing to what God hates; silencing her conscience; making him a second lord	Gentle and quiet toward him; subject as to the Lord; speaking truth in love; refusing to join iniquity; seeking the church's help when the house is in danger
Husband toward wife	Abdicating; being harsh and then "apologizing" without change; people-pleasing; treating her honor as optional; using meek language while withholding love	Giving himself up; living with knowledge; showing honor as a fellow heir; not bitter; washing her with the word; protecting her from evil, including his own

Forgiveness is commanded. Remaining in unrepentant violence is not. Humility does not baptize abuse. A spouse who keeps lowering themselves under cruelty is not becoming more like Jesus. Jesus submitted to the Father's will, not to the Sanhedrin's lie as if it were righteousness.

V. God's Definition in One Place

Humility, as God defines it, is lowliness of mind under His hand: fearing Him, receiving His word, walking justly, clothing yourself toward others, and — above all — sharing the mind of Christ who became a servant and obeyed unto death.

- **What it looks like:** teachability, service, tears, patience, considering others, meek correction, honor instead of self-exaltation, a home where both spouses bow to Christ first.
- **What it is not:** false self-abasement, angel-religion, body-hatred, mock kneeling, fear of man, silence that protects sin, or a marriage where one image-bearer is erased.
- **Too much of the real thing?** No. God keeps saying humble yourselves. He never says stop.
- **Too much toward a spouse?** Not of Philippians 2 and Ephesians 5:21–33. Yes of any “humility” that unseats God, enables evil, or refuses the duty God assigned to wife or husband.

The proud He opposes. The humble He graces. He exalts them in due time — not because they found a trick called low self-image, but because they agreed with Him about who is Lord.

Humility - God's Definition. Built from the BibleHub HUMILITY search (36 verses) plus the Hebrew/Greek field those verses sit in. Scripture quoted in English sense from the common evangelical text tradition (NASB-style). Not a substitute for reading the passages in full.

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